

4-2000

The Yale Political Quarterly 2000 April

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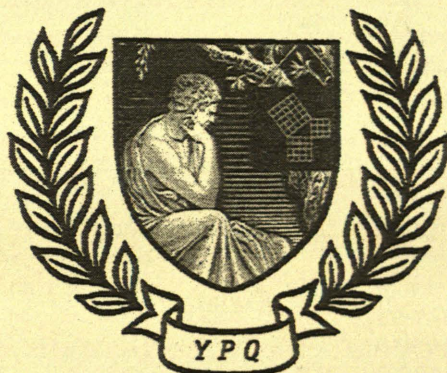
The Politic, Inc., "The Yale Political Quarterly 2000 April" (2000). *The Politic*. 47.
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Yale^{The} Political Quarterly

An Undergraduate Publication

VOLUME 21, NUMBER 3, APRIL 2000



Daniel O'Connor

School Shootings
and the Crisis of
Social Alienation in
American Education

FOUNDED 1979

Aaron Johanson

'What the Hell
Happened?'
An Analysis of
the New Hampshire
Primary

Michael Orona

Has Anything Changed Since
Tiananmen?

A Realistic Appraisal of China's 'Rebirth'

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THE YALE POLITICAL QUARTERLY
PO Box 200455
New Haven, CT 06520

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The Voice of a New China?

Michael Orona

AS A NEW DECADE DAWNS, RESEARCHERS, POLITICAL ANALYSTS, AND ECONOMISTS rush to try to understand what role China will play in the years that follow. What eventually becomes of the People's Republic of China may be largely left for time to decipher. Time may also prove to be the most formidable adversary, as it is something that the Chinese leadership is running out of.

Chinese President Jiang Zemin has made it very clear that China intends to forge partnerships toward the trend of multipolarization. The theory calls for China to establish peaceful coexistence with other nations of the world despite different political, religious and economic systems. The Chinese version of this endeavor is intent on opposing hegemony, power politics, and the interference with a country's sovereignty by outside forces. Furthermore, in a recent speech, Jiang continued to stress China's role as a supporter and representative of the developing countries of the world.

What China intends to portray to the world and what it is in fact becoming are two quite different objectives. While China may claim to support the theory of multipolarization, it continues to come up short on its pledge. In advocating peaceful partnerships, China continues to move ever closer toward making the South China Sea its sole possession. In its claim to represent the interest of developing nations throughout the world, China again falls short. The leadership continually fails to actively support developing countries by refusing to join any functional or geographic groups found in the United Nations.¹ The sole purpose of these groups is to

allow the developing nations the opportunity to meet in order to solve the social, political and economic problems they are facing. This contrast between proposed policy formulation and actual implementation has left the world community to contemplate what indeed the new voice of China will be. Is the leadership in Beijing willing to march in unison with other nations toward a New World Order, or is it intent on marching to the beat of its own drummer? In solving this question one needs only to reexamine the events of ten years past.

Tiananmen Square: Forgotten and Forbidden

Ten years has passed since the Tiananmen massacre, and it is still an unspoken rule on the streets of Beijing that it is best neither to mention nor even to remember anything associated with June 1989. The 10th Anniversary of the Tiananmen Square Massacre passed with little trouble. While a few brave souls were inclined to remember the tenth anniversary through public displays, Tiananmen (literally, "Gate of Heavenly Peace") for the most part remained true to its name. The Chinese government planned meticulously to ensure that the display of ten years ago would not be repeated. The square was therefore closed for renovation. Extra uniformed and undercover police were also enlisted to follow or arrest anyone who looked remotely suspicious.

While the tenth anniversary of Tiananmen passed largely unmarked, the world was witness to a grand style celebration

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last October. October 1, 1999 marked the 50th Anniversary of the founding of People's Republic of China. As Chinese tanks rumbled past Tiananmen Square for the second time in ten years, a sense of historical amnesia seemed to drift over the huge crowd that had amassed to celebrate the founding of the PRC. Amidst all the flag waving and roar of jets over head, it may have been difficult even in the private chambers of their mind for anyone to have remembered China's brave souls who a decade earlier gave their life in that same square. Like the refurbished tiles of Tiananmen and the newly painted façade of the 500 year old Forbidden City, the Chinese government seems intent to have whitewashed the rough exterior of the past rather than painstakingly address the problems of the present. What may be even more staggering is the fact that except for a select few who dare to speak out against the present social and economic inequalities, the Chinese leaders seem to have the consent of the nation. After only a decade, citizens who once called for social and political reform have now willingly conceded to the national leadership. What then has been the underlying success of the Chinese government in its attempt to fully excise its historical ghosts?

Ten Years Ago vs. The Present: More of the Same

In finding answers to this question one may first presume that China ten years later is a much different place. In the last decade the world was witness to China's accelerated economic reform and advancement onto the world stage. The man most responsible for leading China's economic reform was the same person who was in power during the Tiananmen massacre—Deng Xiaoping. It is for the former rather than the latter that Deng is most remembered. Deng's vision of economic reform has indeed transformed, at least outwardly, today's Chinese cities into social and economic centers. Automobiles now rival bicycles on city streets, skyscrapers and glass towers are now replacing the older neighborhoods or *hutongs*, while

business suites have prevailed over the Mao suite.

The last ten years have brought about dramatic improvements in the daily life of an average Chinese citizen. An increase in health-care provisions, transportation, and access to education has greatly added to the quality of life. In the last decade, per-capita income has quadrupled to \$150 U.S. per month, while life expectancy for urban dwellers has risen to nearly seventy years.

While economic reform has indeed brought about some improvements, it has failed to address the cause of other social inequalities. One might even state that these reforms might have been the root cause for the demise in the first place. The economic reform initiated by Deng and now carried over by Jiang has not been able to keep up with the social reforms that Chinese citizens were promised.

The process of economic reform first took shape in the late 1970's. Deng's attempt was to stimulate growth through the expansion of trade without a disruption of the old system. However, the means to achieve a true socialist market economy were never clearly defined. What indeed has been expressed is the need to reform the state owned enterprises. State enterprises make up the inefficient, technologically obsolete, and unproductive manufacturing sectors of the country. It has been reported that they account for over seventy-two percent of industrial assets, while accounting for only 34 percent of total industrial output. Their survival can only be attributed to government funding and subsidies rather than revenues.

In reality, economic reform has essentially been a combination of restoration of land to the tiller and the creation of new forms of economic organization.² While a limited few have benefited from economic reform, a large majority of the population still remains unemployed, uneducated, and underrepresented. Therefore, what economic reform has achieved is a threatening of the vested interest of a large and powerful group, namely 100 million work-

ers and party cadres in the traditional state owned enterprises.³

For over half a century, state enterprises have provided pensions, housing, education, and other social services for their workers and their families. In the fall of 1997, Jiang announced that acceleration of the reform of the state owned enterprise would begin. One reform called for major layoffs, in which as many as 15 million would lose their jobs. 20 million retired workers are said to be supported by state enterprises, and such enterprises pay out 18 to 20 percent of their payroll to the pension system. These archaic giants have reached the point where they are now unable to provide social safety nets as once before and are attempting to transfer their responsibility to other enterprises.

While the 76 million workers of the state owned enterprises are under threat of being terminated without social services, it is still a far cry from what the rural population must face. In 1995, more than 100 million unemployed rural workers were reported to have migrated into China's cities in search of work

and a better lifestyle.

A majority of the adult rural workers that have entered the cities is illiterate with little more than a third grade education. While a large portion of the "floating population," as they are now termed, are of Han ancestry, much of

the unemployed population also represents the numerous minority groups of the Chinese hinterland. Members of the floating population, because of their lack of education, are confined to manual labor. Those that have tried to excel by entrepreneurial means have been met by harsh treatment at the hands of the Chinese government.

Nevertheless, a majority of the floating population has ventured into providing trades and services. Many have opened their own food vending stalls, supply shops, or fix-it shops. Quite often, members of the same population that have entered the city from rural areas support these new businesses in their new endeavor. When police and government officials are made aware of these "illegal" operations, they are closed and destroyed with little or no warning. As the police have continued to crackdown on illegally operating businesses, many are forced to seek alternatives by less appropriate means such as prostitution, begging, and criminal activity. Many government officials have come to the conclusion that it would be best to "guide" members of the rural population back to the countryside. However, ideas of how to establish employment opportunities in the Chinese hinterland have yet to be developed.

While China is made up of 3.7 million square miles, only 10 percent is available for cultivation. Even so, the Chinese government has reported a decline of cultivated land. From 1949-1992, cultivated land declined by 2.51 percent.⁴ The reason for the loss of land can be linked to several factors which include desertification, deforestation, and the fact that farmers have taken to the idea of raising high-yielding cash crops over organic alternatives. The failure to plant organic alternatives is due in part to the government's failure to raise the price of produce in order to keep with the high costs of fuel, fertilizer, and other farming expenses. Farmers are thus faced with two options. One is to rely on planting cash crops that will eventually decline in yield; the other is to migrate into the city, become illegal residents, and face the consequences that await them there.

Reports from the World Bank indicate that in 1993 the income for urban residents jumped 12 percent from the previous year while in the same amount of time the income for a rural worker rose only two percent. The report from the World Bank goes on to state that they believe that the opportunities to re-

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duce poverty through rural industry and agricultural growth were exhausted by the mid-1980's.

Efforts have been made to curb the tide of the surplus working population from entering into the cities. The most recent attempts were designed with the 50th anniversary of the PRC in mind. As the anniversary approached, it was reported by numerous international news agencies that members of the floating population were being rounded up and moved out of Beijing. Reports indicate that close to 100,000 people including members of the homeless population as well as the mentally ill were banished from the city and taken out to areas of the countryside and placed in halfway homes. Upon their arrival they were told not to return until all planned festivities were concluded. Reports also indicate that citizens who live outside of Beijing were not being allowed to enter the capital city until the completion of the celebration. Chinese tourist agencies were also prohibited from organizing tours to Beijing during activities commemorating the 50th anniversary.

The Falun Gong Movement

In the early morning hours in April 25, 1999, 10,000 Chinese citizens surround the residence and governmental offices of the Chinese leadership. Silent protesters demanding government recognition of their religious beliefs and practices besieged the compound known as Zhongnanhai. The protesters were part of the Falun Gong movement which incorporates meditation, Qigong (breathing and physical exercises), clean living standards, and aspects of Buddhism and Taoism as well as other religious beliefs into their daily lives.

The Chinese leadership as well as its intelligence agencies, which since the Tiananmen massacre, have prided themselves on knowing the movements of all local and national groups, were completely caught by surprise. The most alarming aspect was that the protesters had mounted mass demonstrations in thirty cities around the country. The

Chinese leadership became uneasy knowing that such a large group could be mobilized and remain undetected. Perhaps even more frightening to the leadership was the fact that members of the Chinese Communist Party were also listed in the membership rolls of the Falun Gong.

The Falun Gong movement claims a membership of over 10 million but others suggest that actual memberships is closer to around 2 million. Because of their large numbers and their willingness to seek recognition to their cause, the Falun Gong movement has now been labeled by the government as a threat to the country's social and political stability. As is usually the case during such threats, the central government has enlisted the help and support of the state sponsored media. The media were mobilized to inform citizens not become involved in such a movement. Articles began to appear in several newspapers reporting that members of the movement were involved in child abduction, murder, and other illegal activities.

When the media blitz did not stop supporters in their quest to seek recognition, the government outlawed the practice and began to initiate harsh punishments. Hundreds of thousands of supporters have been placed under arrest, tortured and intimidated in an attempt to have members renounce their belief. The government has gone as far as to put a bounty on the leader of the Falun Gong Movement, Li Hongzhi. A reward of \$6,000 U.S. has been offered to any one who can supply information leading to the arrest of Li.

Equality Denied

China's continued move toward reform in an effort to increase economic well being has not reached all the different segments of Chinese society. It is a slow and lengthy process that will not reach marginalized members for several years. However, reform for some groups may best be reached if they are allowed to voice their concerns.

China's move toward reform has also

brought about little change for any of the country's minority groups. One example is the case of the Uighur minority group. The Uighurs, whose language is Turkish based, make their home in the province of Xinjiang in western China. When the Chinese Communists conquered the region in 1949, the population was 93 percent Uighur Muslim and 7 percent Han Chinese. Today, the Uighurs are only 47 percent of the population, with Han Chinese getting the best jobs in government, industry, commerce and newly built oil refineries.⁵ For years the group has called for complete autonomy and independence. Within the last two years, the members of this Moslem minority group have proceeded in their quest for self-determination by targeting and bombing several strategic government locations.

The last ten years may claim to have brought economic advances to some segments of Chinese society. Some China watchers argue that such reform is leading the country down a road toward social and political chaos while others claim that China has the fortitude necessary to withstand such turmoil. All are agreed, however, that the last ten years will be remembered as a focal point in the history of the PRC.

China's Answer

The international community will always remember June 4, 1989 as a time of mounting social and political unrest in China. Those in the West seem intent on remembering the students and their quest for reform. While continually reexamining only the topical aspect of the events of that time, we in the West may have confined our assessment too narrowly and therefore failed to truly understand the social and political significance of that time. While limiting our view only to the students and their call for reform, albeit a heroic and important aspect, we failed to recognize another movement that was taking place. A second group, made up mostly of Chinese scholars, felt that their country was not ready to make a move toward democracy. Instead

these scholars called for a period of neoauthoritarian rule. Adherents to this political belief felt that their view would first lead to full-scale economic development. They believed that a strong economy must be the foundation on which reform would take place. Only then, after economic development was established, could China move toward democracy.

After the effects of Tiananmen, the Chinese leadership was filled with a sense of uncertainty. A way in which to unite the citizens of China under one common view was desperately needed. The neoauthorian scholars were eager to put their idea to the masses. At the same time they did not want to seem overtly critical of those in power. They reached safe ground by employing an age old method of protest know as Jia-Qian.⁶ This classical Chinese style of comment, named after emperors Jia Qing and Qian Long, would be incorporated to express the ideas of the neoauthoritarians.

These scholars were about to chart a dramatic change in course and steer China toward a political trend that it had not seen in decades. The basis of Jia-Qian allowed for a shift in political examination. The Neoauthoritarians called for a look inward toward Chinese culture and traditions. With this style of research, a new appreciation for all things Chinese begin to take form. Almost instantly, papers, articles, and research intent on highlighting language, culture, and tradition were published. Chinese-centered curriculum began to emphasize a value system intent on examining its own superiority and discrediting things that were foreign.

This form of scholarship, which led to the social, historical, and political appreciation of the past, began to call for China to regain its lost territories as well as to restore lost pride and dignity. Interest in the ideals of the West would now be held by only a select few. Only ten years after Tiananmen, the Chinese government had a foundation on which to unite its citizenry. Unbridled Chinese nationalism was unleashed.

The resurgence of Chinese nationalism has had its most notable effects within the last year. The inadvertent bombing of the Chinese Embassy in Belgrade by American forces elicited a response that was unanticipated by the West. Shortly after the incident, the government-supported media went to work to awaken the nationalistic fervor of students and citizens alike. Daily publications portrayed those killed in the bombing as "martyrs for the motherland." Horrid photos of the deceased taken after their untimely death were continually shown on the evening news.

Articles in daily newspapers called for China to align its military power with the Serbs and take on the U.S. and its NATO allies. Books with titles such as "China will not be bullied or tricked," and "Glorious China" were written in a matter of weeks. Students were informed that they could best help the Serbs by sending donations to the Yugoslavian Embassy in Beijing. By week's end, it was estimated that thousands of dollars were received along with letters written by Chinese students asking permission to join the Serbian military force.

While students attacked the American Consulate in the southern province of Sichuan, the Embassy in Beijing was battered with stones and Molotov Cocktails. The most noticeable aspect of the protest was the organization and well thought out planning that it incorporated. Students lined up in front of the embassy moving forward row by row as they hailed their projectiles of choice toward the embassy. The most striking display of organization was the fact that the Chinese government provided free transportation for students who wished to take part in the protest.

"We will work unremittingly for the lofty cause of world peace and development." These were the words spoken by President Jiang Zemin to mark the 50th anniversary of the founding of the People's Republic of China. The president's promising words of peace and prosperity were only another in a series of contradictions issued to the world community by China as it showcased its military hardware. The Dong Feng-31 Missile along with Russian

SU-27 Fighters, the T-90 Tank and the Chinese-made Flying Leopard fighter-bomber all made their way into the celebration.

The Dong Feng-31, which had never been seen by the public, made its anticipated debut in the anniversary parade. This intercontinental missile, whose name means "East Wind," has a range of nearly 5,000 miles. This type of range gives the Dong Feng the capability of easily striking China's Asian neighbors as well as Alaska and Hawaii. Most experts estimate that this missile will be fully operational in two years.

The Chinese 50th anniversary parade was reminiscent of a Soviet style military display of the cold war era. Male and female troops carried machine guns and goose-stepped their way past the Chinese leadership as towering portraits of Mao Zedong, Deng Xiaoping, and Jiang Zimen were paraded down the Avenue of Eternal Peace. To mark the anniversary, the Chinese government issued a newly designed 100 Yuan bill. This banknote will replace the profiles of Zhou En Lai, Zhu De and Liu Shaoqi with Mao Zedong in front of a red backdrop.

It is still interesting to note that the man most responsible for China's economic reform, Deng Xiaoping, fails to appear on China's currency, as the Cult of Mao is anything but dead.

Where Have all the Flowers Gone?

The Chinese government, eager to prove to the world the progress that has been made during the last fifty years, spent billions of dollars on ceremonial festivities. Prominent older buildings were repainted. Flowers adorned Tiananmen Square as well as major thoroughfares of Beijing. Slogans were painted on billboards predicting China's move toward greatness.

The Chinese 50th anniversary parade was reminiscent of a Soviet style military display of the cold war era.

While grass was planted and festive lights were put into place, China's poor continued to live in poverty. As patriotic speeches were given throughout the country, millions wondered in search of work. It is inevitable. The grass may now be green but it will eventually turn brown; the lights will grow dim, and the paint will fade. It is then that Beijing will have to answer its most serious questions. The current problems that China faces will not diminish. The Chinese leadership will not be able to ignore the mounting social and economic problems and continue to hide behind empty promises. The most dangerous aspect of Chinese nationalism is that it cannot be sustained without an enemy. Beijing hardliners have identified the United States and Japan as possible adversaries. When China runs out of excuses it may revert to narrowing in on such an enemy in order to keep its nationalistic fervor kindled. As is usually the case in such circumstances, it will be the citizens of the nation who will pay the price. In the end, nationalism will not be able to satisfy the spiritual needs, relieve the hunger pangs and remedy the economic inequalities of the Chinese people.

As one of the final acts of the 50th anniversary celebration, children gathered near a memorial tower centered in Tiananmen Square. As they waved and smiled, one young woman who witnessed the activity may have expressed it best when she stated, "Look at those children, they are so happy and full of love and energy. They are the future of my country and I hope that they will be able to share that peaceful feeling with the rest of the world." That indeed is the same hope of the international community as well.

¹ Michael Yahuda, "China's Search for a Global Role," 98 *Current History* (September 1999): 267.

² The Economist Intelligence Unit, *Country Profile: China/Mongolia*, Fall 1998.

³ Neil Hughes, "Smashing the Iron Rice Bowl," 77 *Foreign Affairs* (August 1998): 73.

⁴ Cheng Li, "200 Million Mouths Too Many," *The China Reader* (New York: Vintage Books, 1999), 362.

⁵ Al Santoli, "China Reform Monitor," *American Foreign Policy Council*, November 24, 1999.

⁶ Michael Dutton, "An All Consuming Nationalism," 98 *Current History* (September 1999): 278.

"WHAT THE HELL HAPPENED?"

An Analysis of the New Hampshire Primary

Aaron Johanson

THE STORY OF DAVID AND GOLIATH IS THE TIMELESS BIBLICAL STORY OF HOW A young would-be king defied all odds with the help of God and defeated in single combat the seemingly formidable giant Goliath. With slingshot in hand, David miraculously brought down the giant with a fatal launching of one stone right between Goliath's eyes. In recent days, the Republican race for the presidential nomination seems to be coming down to final battle between a political Goliath, Governor George W. Bush of Texas and a would-be king of the Republican Party, Senator John McCain of Arizona. With the race narrowing to these two candidates and struggling die-hard conservative Alan Keyes, both men know that they need to gear up for the political fight of their lives. Bush, the current front-runner and party favorite, knows that his staying power and viability as the strongest candidate must remain even in the face of McCain's strong onslaught in the New Hampshire primary. A seasoned veteran, McCain also realizes the extent to which his campaign depends on strong showings in the upcoming Republican primaries against his colossal foe. The face-off between these two candidates has political pundits and politicians closely following every development in the campaign. New developments have abounded day after day in this race, but the greatest development by far has been the results in New Hampshire, the nation's first primary. If George Bush and John McCain were to face each other for the nomination, just how likely is a McCain upset of Bush? Is George Bush the inevitable nominee of the Republican Party? A closer analysis of the New Hampshire primary reveals some of the reasons for McCain's success and the possible implications that this primary could have on the campaigns of each candidate. Although it seems that the New Hampshire primary could be the stone that smacks Goliath right between the eyes, it is unlikely that this trumped-up event will completely dictate the rest of the race.

Arizona Senator John McCain is no stranger to politics; he currently presides over the important and very influential Senate Appropriations Committee. Previously, Senator McCain was best known for the issue of campaign finance reform, a cause he championed all the way to the creation of the McCain-Feingold Campaign Finance Reform Bill. Enter John McCain, former POW and Vietnam War hero, veteran servant of the people, and a politician with more on his mind than campaign finance reform: the crown jewel of his Senate career. With his sights broadened and set on the Oval Office, McCain has garnered significant attention lately for his growing emergence in the national political arena. McCain's emergence is a result of many factors that could very well help him accomplish his goal of becoming Commander in Chief.

The results of this year's New Hampshire's primary election are now a facet of national discourse on the issue of the presidency and, more specifically, the Republican party nomination. McCain achieved a commanding victory over front-runner Bush by a nineteen-point margin.¹ The elation of the McCain campaign stood in stark contrast to the reeling of the flabbergasted Bush team. The Bush team did not expect such a crushing defeat in the primary that all front-runners historically dread. Although New Hampshire is by no means representative of the entire United States, Thomas Patterson, in his book about the America's political process, asserts that New Hampshire's importance has gradually increased over time to its present state of being a "must-win" situation for candidates.² Thus, Bush's loss in New Hampshire could have wide-ranging ramifications. In the first national test of the candidates, McCain triumphed, and the media responded by showering him with increased attention while Bush's campaign appeared to be weakening and received little more than raised eyebrows. Even Bush himself revealed his surprise and dismay when he gathered his advisors together and inquired, "what the hell happened?"³ Regardless of why things turned out the way they

did, the reality is that McCain won the New Hampshire primary by a commanding margin. Although Patterson makes an interesting point that this particular primary is important, one must not forget previous candidates behind whom New Hampshire voters threw their support. In 1996, Pat Buchanan beat out eventual Republican nominee Bob Dole in the Granite State. It is not as though New Hampshire serves as an accurate gauge of national sentiment and opinions. On the contrary, New Hampshire voters have often differed from the rest of the nation. This unusual phenomenon occurs because "New Hampshire is politically weird...its Democrats aren't much like other Democrats, and its Republicans aren't much like other Republicans."⁴ Perhaps these political differences lie in New Hampshire's inherent socio-economic differences. McCain's straight talk style appeals most to the state's citizens who are by and large well off and uncharacteristically well educated.⁵ Without depriving John McCain of his due credit, it seems that New Hampshire itself is so different that any typical election outcome would be somewhat atypical in this state. Thus, what happened is partly a result of New Hampshire's "politically weird" nature.

If New Hampshire is such a fluke, then why is the McCain campaign so happy and the Bush campaign feverishly racing to minimize the "damage?" Although it would be a gross extrapolation to equate New Hampshire with the rest of the nation, its primary nonetheless has important consequences for both candidates. John McCain's win in New Hampshire probably corresponded to gains made in polls around the country. This correlation reflects polling success and to some extent, caused further polling success. In Delaware, for example, McCain chose not to campaign at all, never stopping in the state or spending a dollar there, yet he won twenty-five percent of the vote.⁶ Furthermore, Bush's lead in the all-important state of South Carolina declined as people saw that he was not the inevitable Republican nominee or the best candidate for president.⁷ South Carolina is a key state that will test the staying

power of McCain and Bush's ability to come back from a stinging defeat. In addition to these two states, McCain's New Hampshire victory helped to propel him higher in national polls and ratings with a favorable rating of seventy-six percent, the highest of any national presidential candidate.⁸ McCain's prominence and viability increased with New Hampshire, exactly what the fledgling candidate going up against a Goliath needed to maintain his bid for the presidency.

As many candidates are well aware, the media's help is an important part of securing the presidency. New Hampshire is so important to John McCain because he can use it to launch his career, just as the upstart Jimmy Carter used the relatively unknown Iowa caucuses in the 1976 primary season.⁹ McCain knows that the media play a critical element in politics, for they hold the key to reaching the American body politic. They investigate the facts that form the basis of stories; they select the candidate's coverage; and they conduct the polls of national audiences that gauge a candidate's supposed popularity and viability. In performing all of these activities, the media consequently shape the public's perception of the candidates, often a more valuable asset than any of the candidate's other qualities. Think about it...do you actually know George Bush or John McCain? The American public sometimes feels intimately connected with its politicians because this relationship is one of the most fundamental tenants of our founding father's political doctrine. In truth, unless a person has vigorously researched all position statements, previous votes cast, and various other details of that candidate's life, he/she probably knows relatively little about a candidate. John McCain has never shied away from the press; in fact, "he's worked the precincts of the press corps like an Irish pol in Southie on St. Patrick's Day, offering his near-obsessive candor and availability to reporters reared in an era of antagonism between the media and the politicians."¹⁰ The media provide that vital link that keeps the American populous feeling like it is in touch with the people who are

running or will be running the government.

The majority of Americans are content to view a candidate through the lens of the media. In this instance, John McCain and George Bush become who the media paint them as. Do you hear about John McCain, the war hero who pulled off an astonishing victory against front-runner George Bush, or do you hear about the candidate who won in a state that historically votes differently from everywhere else and sometimes makes little impact in the overall election? These two very different portrayals are both accurate, yet they conjure up completely different images in one's mind. The first description paints the portrait of a winner, while the second paints a more toned-down picture of someone who has a long way to go. Besides the everyday rhetoric about the two candidates, national polls also bombard our political conscience. The polls have the ability to project images of potential winners and losers. Take the recent CNN poll that shows McCain gaining ground and high in favorable ratings. Polls like this improve his chances because he suddenly becomes a much more viable candidate, one that we can all vote for in good conscience as the voters of Delaware saw and those in South Carolina may witness.

No one disagrees with the immediate significance of McCain's win in New Hampshire, but what remains to be seen is the lasting implications this win will have nationally. At present, Senator McCain has a stunning win in New Hampshire, an abundance of media attention, and rising popularity in polls to add to his political credentials. However, Governor Bush has majority of party support which will help at the Republican National Convention. At the convention, Bush can probably expect the support of the "super delegates" (1/3 of the national convention), those individuals like governors, senators, not directly chosen by voters for the convention.¹¹ Furthermore, Bush will have the likely support of states with large numbers of delegates like Texas and Florida. Thus, the historically important status and distinct nature of New

Hampshire coupled with the subsequent media attention derived from the win contributed enormously to the prevailing view of Senator McCain as the underdog who could potentially win the Republican nomination, the David who might triumph over Goliath. Even though New Hampshire is important, it is by no means the stone that may kill the Bush campaign for the nomination. With important primaries to come, Bush has every opportunity to prove that he is still the giant in his party. McCain's win is more of a wake-up call to Bush than a stone between the eyes. Goliath may be temporarily waning, but he is still very much alive, if not more reinvigorated than ever.

07/cnn.poll/>

⁹ Howard Fineman, "The McCain Mutiny," *Newsweek*, 14 February 2000, Online: http://newsweek.com/nw-srv/web/special/campaign2000/sr01_020700.htm

¹⁰ Howard Fineman, "The McCain Mutiny," *Newsweek*, 14 February 2000, Online: http://newsweek.com/nw-srv/web/special/campaign2000/sr01_020700.htm

¹¹ Dick Morris, "Will It Be Bradley vs. McCain?", VOTE.COM, 25 February 2000, Online: <http://www.vote.com/magazine/columns/dickmorris/column230599.phtml>

¹ Howard Fineman, "The McCain Mutiny," *Newsweek*, 14 February 2000, Online: http://newsweek.com/nw-srv/web/special/campaign2000/sr01_020700.htm

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³ Nancy Gibbs, "McCain's Moment," *TIME*, 14 February 2000, Online: <http://www.pathfinder.com/time/magazine/articles/0,3266,38790,00.html>

⁴ The Editors, "They Only Look Alive", *The New Republic*, 02 February 2000, Online: <http://www.tnr.com/021400/editorial021400.html>

⁵ The Editors, "They Only Look Alive", *The New Republic*, 02 February 2000, Online: <http://www.tnr.com/021400/editorial021400.html>

⁶ Tony Karon, "The Fight Is On for the Forbes Faction", *Time*, 09 February 2000, Online: <http://www.pathfinder.com/time/daily/0,2960,38946-101000209,00.html>

⁷ Howard Fineman, "The McCain Mutiny," *Newsweek*, 14 February 2000, Online: http://newsweek.com/nw-srv/web/special/campaign2000/sr01_020700.htm

⁸ Keating Holland, "POLL: McCain the most popular presidential candidate nationwide," *CNN*, 07 February 2000, Online: <http://cnn.com/2000/ALLPOLITICS/stories/02/>

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Deeper into Society's Ills

Daniel O'Connor

SEVENTEEN SCHOOL SHOOTINGS OVER THE PAST DECADE HAVE GRIPPED THE UNITED States in horror. While victims and the rest of the nation recover, experts and politicians quickly return us to the gun control and media violence debate. Frustratingly, both Democrats and Republicans essentially agree that societal violence is the cause of school shootings. As a recent YPQ article points out, the role of societal violence in these school shootings is questionable. If indeed societal violence does spawn more violence, societal violence can be only one of many contributing factors. Another factor might be youth alienation and the possible inability of our modern school system to address the issue. The federal government might be able to play an important role in helping states reform their high school systems by providing states with funding that encourage them to construct schools that could address the different needs of different of students.

The societal violence debate, which politicians endlessly engage in, commits four logical fallacies. First, as my YPQ colleague Jason Lott suggests, the debate *begs the question* because "it has yet to be established that identifiable non-local causes" to school shootings are responsible or are conclusively linked to these incidents.¹ Second, the debate commits the closely related *false dilemma* fallacy. In order to decide whether guns or bloody video games cause violence, individuals have to choose one of two equally plausible possibilities. The debate thus becomes a false dilemma because neither option is necessarily incorrect, as "or" would imply.

Third, school shootings may in fact be the result of other causes, or at least the result of a different combination of causes. This would be the *single cause* fallacy where an overly simplified solution becomes the only assumed cause. If guns and the violent media are the only true causes of youth violence, and if every youth has the same access to guns and the violent media as the Columbine shooters, then why haven't there been more shootings?

Finally, the debate seems to commit the *circular reasoning* fallacy. If guns and violence in the media are the causes *and* manifestations of violence, what initially causes the vicious cycle to begin?

Central to these fallacies is the idea that politicians and the media concentrate on these two very broad and vague areas of contention (guns and media violence), and spend little time considering alternative explanations. Consequently, while party elite bicker over the manifestations of violence in our society, they fail to reflect on trends that may more closely relate to the unique phenomenon of youth violence. Such trends may range from the increased pressures on adolescents to teen angst and depression to immaturity to a decreasing sense of control and a loss of meaning for their individual lives. Simple explanations do not exist for such a complex problem, and therefore neither do simple solutions.

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Nevertheless, I would like to offer my own theory on why youth violence occurs and to speculate on the possible solutions. My suggestion is that growing youth alienation in various sectors of student life is one factor involved with youth violence. This alienation might exist not only for academically mature students who may feel as if they have already outgrown high school but also for troubled students who feel peripherized by high school hierarchy. My suggestions to reform high school are to increase state sponsoring of more specialized and accelerated magnet schools, to rethink our encouragement of high school athletics, and to improve and increase tolerance of different racial and economic backgrounds.

First, recent studies suggest that students, even those considered to be top students, are increasingly disengaging from their schoolwork. For instance, the *New York Times* recently released a study that suggests that some schools now have difficulty occupying students who have already surpassed the education the school can offer them. While these schools are encouraging such students to graduate early, the students feel out of place not only if they stay at a high school that does not engage them intellectually but also if they enter college early.² Another study suggests that the average college-bound senior is

increasingly bored with high school, a phenomenon that may linger with these students into their undergraduate careers.³ In addition, increasing pressure to achieve increases student competition and detracts

from learning. Top students are increasingly pursuing their own academic agendas with decreasing interest in their work and an increasing sense that they are alone in their quest for meaningless grades.⁴

Meanwhile, less-academically inclined students can face a similar struggle when trying to achieve a sense of belonging. Econom-

ics and athletics are increasingly dividing modern high school social life. As I just suggested, schools need to be spending more time and resources trying to satisfy the needs of accelerated students. In order even to compete academically, students must make increasingly infeasible sacrifices of time and energy. The gap between successful students and struggling students thus widens because the successful have the opportunity to achieve.⁵ Similarly, activities become largely dominated by and aimed towards students who can afford to participate. Consequently, not only do students who are unable to participate feel left out, but also peripheral students who want to join but feel intimidated not to because of the people who are already participating. These students thus can feel isolated and left out because they do not participate in anything, and may resent the students can easily take advantage of these opportunities.⁶

America's overemphasis on athletics promotes cliques and fuels division. As irrational parental pressure seems to drive students into pursuing such extracurricular activities to learn how to win, students have transformed what should be activities to foster school spirit into ways to exclude others and to secure personal status. Athletes "take advantage of their status" by sliding through class work and by being "popular."⁷ Because high schools place such an high emphasis on athletics, other talents or interests, such as academics or the arts, somehow receive "lower status" and receive less emphasis from parents. Students who pursue other interests tend to feel as if they are different. In budget crunches, certain sports always receive funding while the arts are almost always the first to go, reinforcing the notion that arts are not as important as athletics and that non-athletes are not as important as jocks.

At the same time, "fringe" students resent school officials and others who try to single them out because they perceive such attempts as trying to reinforce the false idea that they are different. "They don't talk to the preppy kids," said Matt Gewinner, a student

Simple explanations do not exist for such a complex problem, and therefore neither do simple solutions.

at Webster Groves High, near St. Louis, Missouri. "They flag the kids that are Goth and wear black."⁸ Mali Pursell, a senior who poses for a *Time* photo wearing a tight black dress, blue hair and a studded leather collar, notices the superficiality of her classmates, characterizing conversations with peers as "'look, I'm talking to the weird girl.'"⁹

I want to say up front that I believe that the gunmen in these various shootings have complete responsibility for their actions, despite the fact that they are children. I do however think that there are some possible connections between some of these ideas and the actual school shootings. For example, in May 1992, Eric Houston, 20, killed four people and wounded ten in an armed siege at his former high school in Olivehurst, California. Prosecutors said the attack was in retribution for a failing grade. In 1996, a 14-year-old student turned an assault rifle on his algebra class, killing two classmates and a teacher, in Moses Lake, Washington.¹⁰ In 1999, Columbine shooters Eric Harris and Dylan Klebold declared that "this is for all the people who made fun of us all these years," laughing as they opened fire.¹¹

I have three suggestions to address these current problems in our high school system. First, I believe it might be necessary to overhaul completely the current high school system. It might be more effective and more rational to provide higher education for individuals who wish to pursue it, and to allow individuals who wish to pursue other education, such as professional or vocational education, to do so. It makes little sense to force students who have no desire to or feel uncomfortable to attend a public schools that does not provide them a relevant education. This solution would involve significant resources in order to restructure high schools, vocational schools and universities. Nevertheless, such a plan would likely create an academic system where students receive a more suitable education and feel as if they belong.

Since this solution may be too idealistic, a more realistic solution that better preserves the high school tradition might for states

to proliferate the use and expansion of state funded magnet schools. Magnet schools can focus on specialize academically and can provide not only accelerated programs for accelerated students but also improved facilities and unique opportunities for students who come from less affluent backgrounds but nevertheless demonstrate academic potential. Under such a system, the state could target a more suitable style of teaching for these gifted students at the magnet schools. In addition, the state could also target a more suitable style of teaching for the students who remain at the local public high schools. Magnet schools would not only better engage all types of students, but also better promote integration of different racial and class backgrounds, since all qualified students would theoretically have equal opportunities to gain admittance and to pursue their education.

Second, schools must do a better job promoting genuine tolerance and understanding of the importance of social and economic diversity. Schools excessively permit cliques that do not encourage students to broaden their understanding of other classmates. Schools that promote better understanding of other backgrounds will undoubtedly create an academic environment where all students can feel comfortable and welcome to pursue their education, however the students themselves wish to define it individually.

Third, school administrators nationwide must de-emphasize the importance of organized sports. While athletics is important for exercise and mental health, as well as providing a social forum, the irrational intensity our culture places upon athletic competition and especially winning seems to distort the virtues of athletics. The promotion of athletics creates a culture of elitism and fosters a high school hierarchy based upon exclusion. If schools adopted a better perspective

School administrators nationwide must de-emphasize the importance of organized sports.

on sports, sports could foster school character and identity as well as provide positive outlets for students without resulting in elitism or exclusion.

In this article, I make three points. First, I point out that the gun control versus media violence debate seems to commit several logical fallacies because the debate does not take into consideration other potential factors involved with school shootings. As Dale Todd, the father of a young man who was wounded in the Columbine assault, points out, these tragedies suggest that "we need to look deeper into society's ills that we're creating kids like this."¹² I suggest that academic and social alienation may currently exist within our youth culture, and point out how this alienation may have been involved with recent shootings. Finally, I offer three reforms for our modern high schools that would theoretically better promote equality, tolerance and inclusion in our schools, thereby minimizing student alienation from schoolwork and classmates.

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³ Associated Press, "College Freshmen 'Bored' By High School Senior Year," *New York Times*, 24 January 2000, Online: <http://www.nytimes.com/>.

⁴ Jacques Steinberg, "For Gatekeepers at Colleges, a Daunting Task of Weeding," *New York Times*, 27 February 2000, Online: <http://www.nytimes.com/>.

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⁶ Ron Stodghill, "Race and Class at a Suburban School," *Time*, 25 October 1999, 95-98.

⁷ Nancy Gibbs, "The Tribes of Webster," *Time*, 25 October 1999, 77-82.

⁸ Flora Tartakovsky "Trying to help a Self-destructive Teen," *Time*, 25 October 1999, 100.

"Critics say that Gore has a tin ear for politics, but that is an insult to base metals everywhere."

— **Michael Kelly**, editor of *The Atlantic Monthly*, in the Winter 2000 issue of *The Harvard Current*.

"Throughout my entire career, I have stood unwaveringly and unhesitatingly on this principle: that a united and indivisible Jerusalem is the capital of the state of Utah."

— **Sen. Orrin Hatch** (R-UT), pandering shamelessly to Jewish voters for his short-lived presidential run, as quoted in the 27 December 1999 issue of *The New Republic*.

"News crews videotaped the throngs of tourists, and tourists videotaped news crews, in the ultimate validation that something big, communal and self-fulfilling was happening there."

— **Tina Kelley**, in the 30 December 1999 *New York Times*, on the preparations in Times Square for New Year's Eve celebrations.

"After all, the sight of all those wealthy and important people in the same place, with scores of famous intellectuals in attendance, surely inspires the same thought in even the most cynical of observers: Come the revolution, we shoot these people first."

— **Paul Krugman**, on the World Economic Forum, a gathering of the world's business and political elite, in his 23 January 2000 *New York Times* column.

"On New Year's Eve most people were worried about their ATMs; others, however, were focused on the Great Pyramid. According to certain British millennialists, former President George Bush would be conducting a Black Mass inside the great Giza structure, summoning evil forces at midnight on behalf of an 'Illuminati elite' of human-reptile hybrids. Bush obviously has a more colorful image overseas than he does here."

— **Charles Paul Freund**, in the March 2000 issue of *Reason Magazine*.

"With as much or more excitement and enthusiasm as . . . when I first made love some 42 years ago."

— Time Warner vice chairman **Ted Turner**, describing how he approached the AOL-Time Warner merger, quoted in the April 2000 issue of *Reason Magazine*.

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